

BBL 2026

Sydney Sixers vs Sydney Thunder · Sydney Cricket Ground · 16 January 2026

Sydney Sixers won by 5 Wickets (16 balls to spare)

	Sydney Thunder	Sydney Sixers
Innings	1st innings	2nd innings (chase)
Score	189	190
Top Scorer	David Warner (110 off 65)	Steve Smith (100 off 42)
Best Bowler	Chris Green 1 wkts · Econ 4.5	Sam Curran 3 wkts · Econ 6.25
Result	Lost	Won

Key Findings

- Smith was unstoppable against right-arm pace (SR 341, 7 sixes), but Sangha's leg spin contained him to SR 100 in 12 balls. Sangha could have been introduced in the powerplay against him.
- Hadley bowled good length outside off to Smith eight times and conceded 26 runs without any adjustment. A simple adjustment after the second six could have saved at least 12 runs.
- Babar Azam scored 47 off 39 largely because Thunder bowled wide outside off and outside leg, which he was able to dispatch easily. Green held him to SR 80 with a tight middle-stump line.

Pages 2–6 contain supporting analysis, with beehive and wagon-wheel visuals for each finding. All insights are written from Thunder's coaching perspective.

Smith Was Unstoppable Against Pace - Sangha Showed the Blueprint

341

Smith vs Pace SR

7

Smith vs Pace Sixes

100

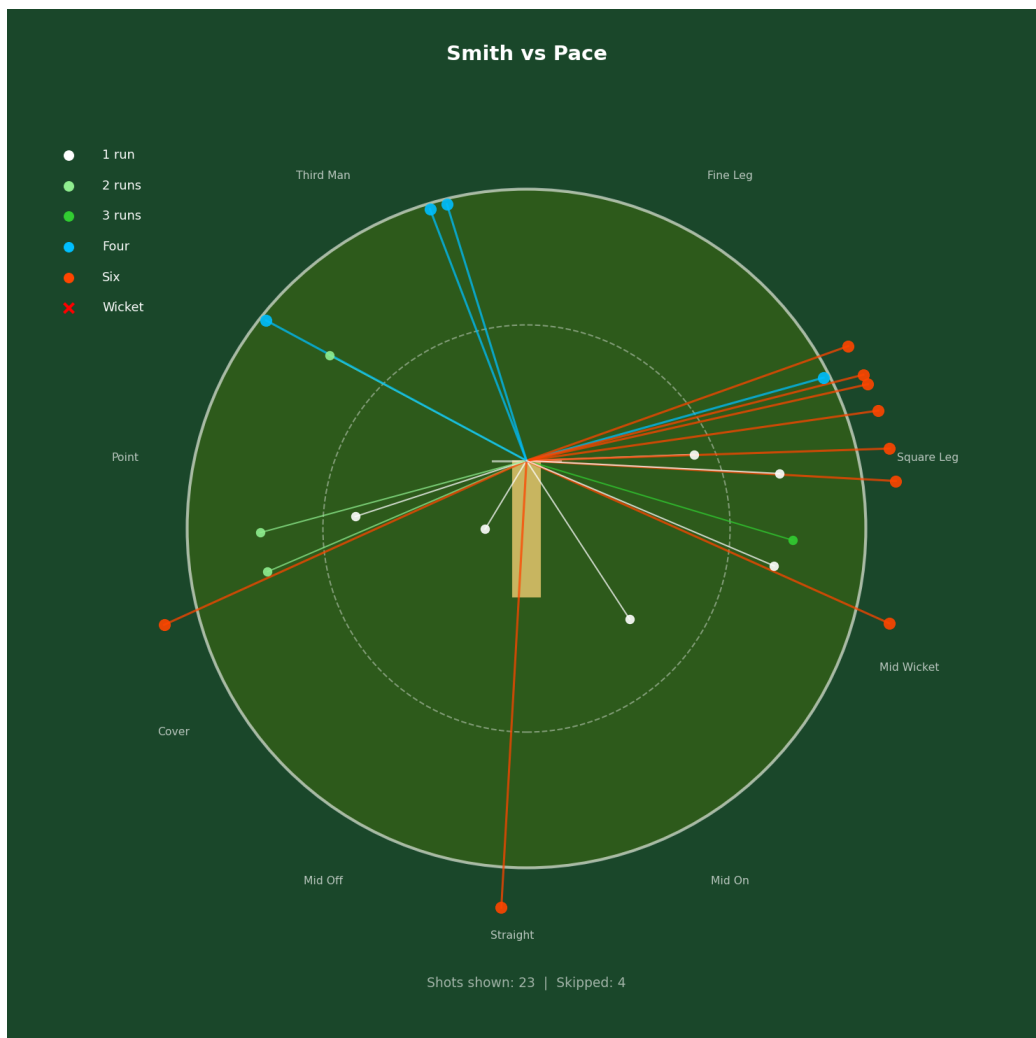
Smith vs Sangha SR

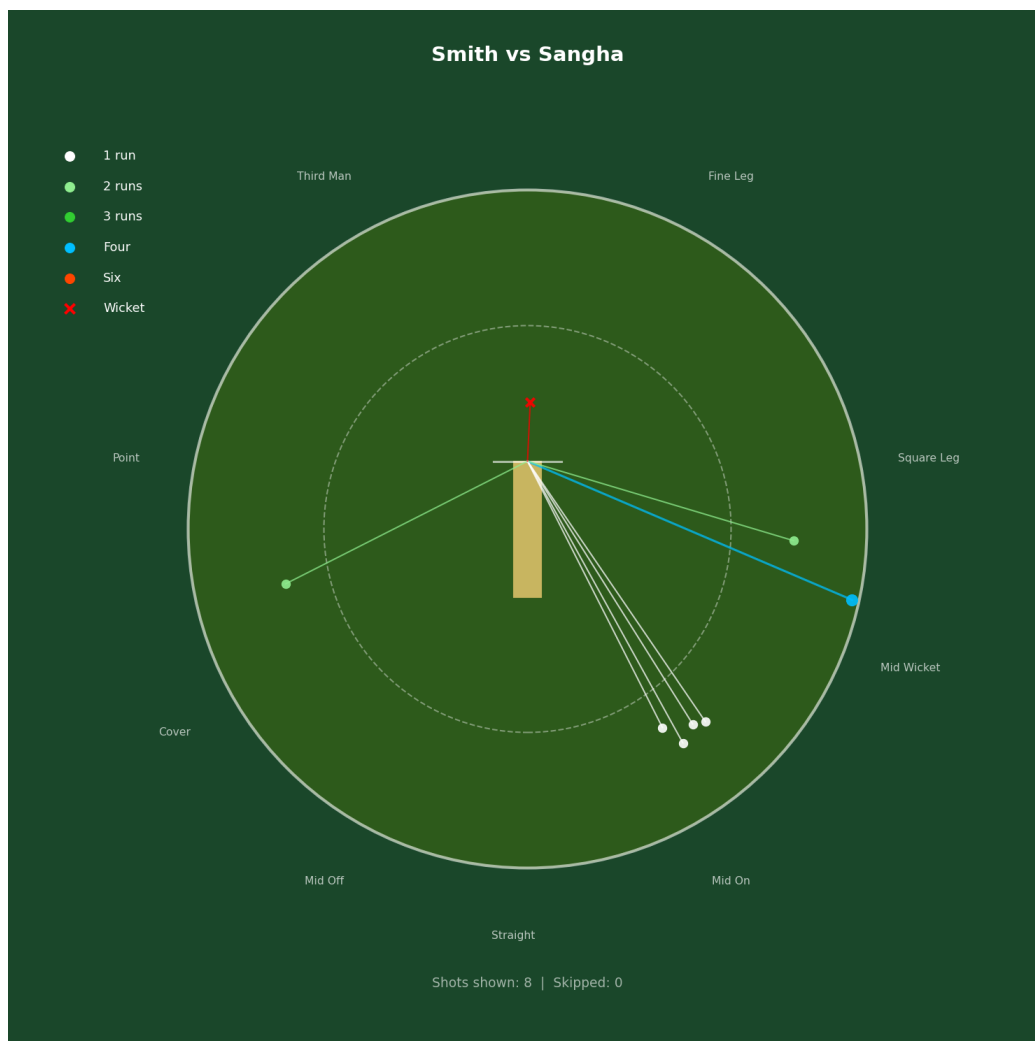
5 from 12

Dots vs Sangha

Steve Smith's innings defined the match. Against right-arm pace and medium-fast bowling, he was in a completely different zone, scoring 82 runs off 24 balls, 7 sixes, attacking from all areas of the ground. Good length outside off was his primary scoring corridor. He hit lofted drives, slogs and lofted flicks at will. Every Thunder pace bowler who landed in that zone paid immediately.

Tanveer Sangha told a completely different story. Bowling on a consistent good length into middle and off stump, he reduced Smith's SR to 100 with 5 dots and 2 beat-bat moments in 12 balls. The contrast between the two wagon wheels below is the clearest visual in this report. One is full of boundaries in every direction. The other is almost empty.





Recommendation: Introduce leg spin against Smith in the powerplay or at first change. Sangha's good-length middle/off line was excellent. Once a batter of Smith's quality is in full flow against pace, containment becomes exponentially harder. The solution was available. The timing of its use was the failure.

INSIGHT 2 OF 3

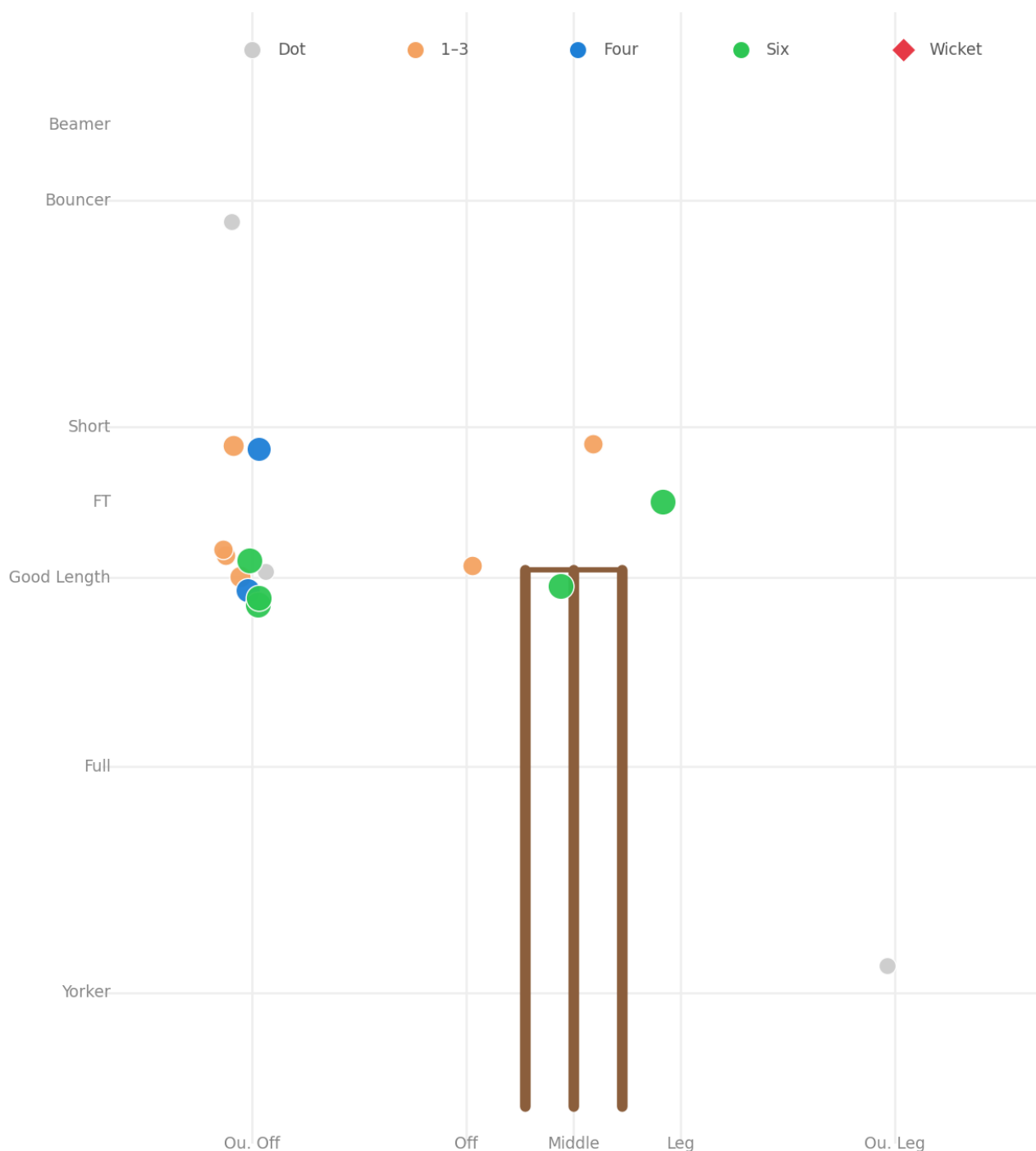
Hadley bowled the same line and length, and never Adjusted

20.5 Economy	26 from 8 balls Outside Off GL — Runs	4 Sixes from That Zone	22.5 Middle Overs Economy
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Ryan Hadley's spell was a turning point in the match. Outside off, good length was his default delivery to Steve Smith, and Smith punished it every time it landed there. Lofted Drive, Lofted Flick, Slog, Square Drive, four different shots, one result, one zone, repeated over and over. The beehive below makes this immediately visible. A cluster of sixes and fours sits in one area. Every other zone is manageable. One zone was expensive.

What separates this from simply being on the wrong end of a Smith masterclass is the absence of any adjustment. After the first six from that zone, a length change to short of length forces a pull rather than a drive, which is a harder scoring shot. After the second six, it becomes a captain's decision as much as a bowler's. Neither the bowler nor the captain made the call. Hadley returned to the same delivery, and Smith kept hitting it out of the ground.

Ryan Hadley — Bowling



Recommendation: Hadley needed a clear mid-spell adjustment. If the same zone is hit for six twice, move the length immediately. Short of length forces a pull rather than a drive and significantly limits lofted scoring options.

Babar Was Never Challenged - Thunder Bowled Straight Into His Strengths

47 off 39

Babar Total

200

vs Outside Off GL SR

80 · 9 dots

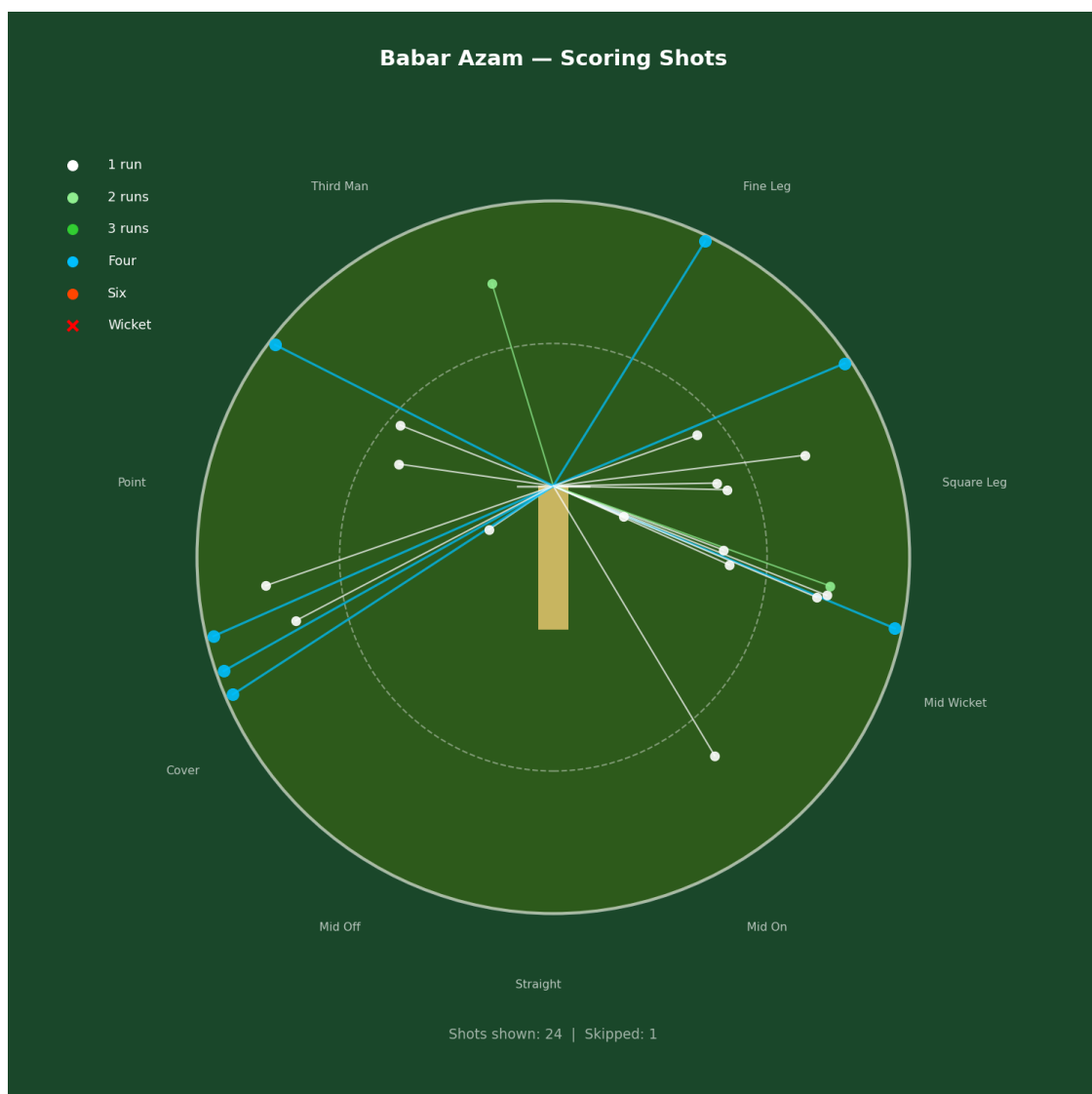
Green vs Babar SR

McAndrew · Short Wide

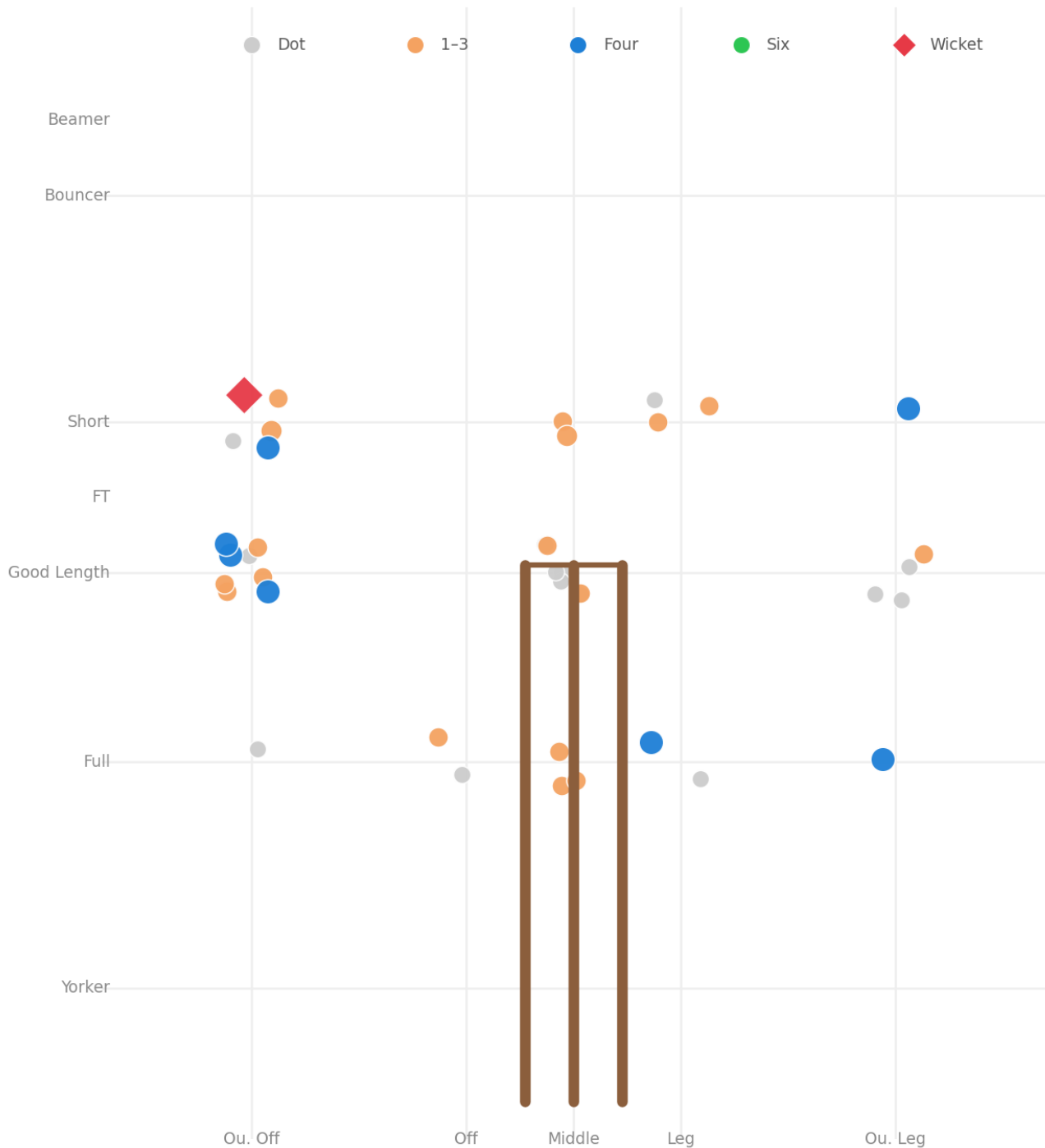
Dismissed By

While Smith's century was crucial, Babar Azam's innings was equally decisive. He scored 47 off 39 balls and was never really threatened, because Thunder consistently bowled into his scoring zones without finding a plan to contain him.

Babar's boundary scoring was built on two zones: width outside off, where he hit square drives, cuts and cover drives for 23 runs from 14 balls at SR 165 and anything straying leg side, where he swept and pulled for four immediately. Every boundary he scored came from one of these two zones.



Babar Azam — Balls Faced



The Chris Green Blueprint

Chris Green was able to contain Babar, bowling right-arm off spin on a tight middle-stump line, he held him to 12 runs off 15 balls with 9 dots SR 80. Babar had no width to cut or drive, no room to sweep, and no pace to work with.

His dismissal adds another layer. McAndrew eventually bowled Babar with a short, wide delivery outside off that he tried to drive and edged onto the stumps. The ball that dismissed him was in a similar zone to his scoring shots, but angled in sharply enough to get the inside edge.

Recommendation: Bowl Babar on a middle-stump line with no width outside off. Green proved this works. The square drive and cut are his primary weapons, and both require width to execute. A straight, full line removes those shots entirely. Equally, avoid straying leg side, any ball there was swept or pulled for four without hesitation.